Traces of the “Bauhaus” in the Şakirin Mosque

“To what extent does the Şakirin Mosque follow the Bauhaus philosophy of ‘form follows function’?”

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Introduction

The Bauhaus philosophy originates from a German art and design school founded by the architect Walter Gropius in Germany, in 1919. The Bauhaus movement had a significant influence on design philosophy and has forever changed the way humanity approaches art, design and architecture. To date, the Bauhaus principle is followed in many different areas whether it is the design of a residential unit, an office chair, or an immense skyscraper. This gives reason as to why it is worthy to investigate the practicality of the Bauhaus principle itself, as well as the famous axiom, "form follows function", which was an essential motto in the Bauhaus movement. Many works of architecture seen today follow a modern look, such as the Şakirin Mosque, showing that there must be an obvious reason behind the popularity of modern, simple designs.

Frequent visitors of the Şakirin Mosque who follow the religion of Islam are still able to form a link with the historical and traditional aspects when they enter the mosque, despite the modernisation of its design since they are knowledgeable in the field of Islam. However, those who do not regularly pray or follow the religion of Islam easily turn a blind eye as to the meaning of certain parts of a mosque and may not even be able to form a link between the design and the religion since the architecture of the Şakirin Mosque is so simple and plain compared to the generic mosque design. With the usage of modern materials, plain and functional exterior design, the exterior of the mosque is almost unrecognisable as a place of worship, however, the interior displays a more familiar mosque look. Still, the question arises on whether modernism leads to the neglect of

traditions and certain histories and this research question uncovers the reasoning behind the neglect of traditional mosque features in modern design and the underlying query as to whether the Bauhaus principle promotes the loss of culture through its simple designs. This study includes an on-site investigation of the Şakirin Mosque as well as two other most well-known historical mosques in Istanbul, Turkey, namely the Blue Mosque and the Hagia Sophia Mosque. The latter ones were visited to understand the difference between historical and contemporary mosques, hence broadening the knowledge required to research the modernisation of Turkish mosque designs. Hence some photographs and information were sourced primarily, lessening bias, and increasing the reliability of this exploration.

In addition to this, this research includes a podcast and an interview (collected from reliable and widely accepted sources online as a form of secondary research) with the lead designer of the Şakirin Mosque, Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu. Moreover, information was also obtained from the Semiha Şakir Foundation's official book on the Şakirin Mosque called, "The Şakirin Mosque Within The Legacy of Karacaahmet Cemetery Istanbul". The Semiha Şakir Foundation is a non-profit organisation created by one of Turkey's well known rich families, the Şakir family who financed the construction of the Şakirin Mosque and generally sponsored the project. This foundation also created a book on which introduces the Şakirin Mosque and gives a general outlook on the historical context and meanings behind certain design aspects of the mosque. As a part of primary research, attempts were made to form contact with the designers, unfortunately, the initial architect

of the mosque, Hüsrev Tayla has passed away in 2014 and Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu has not reverted to the emails for an interview request.

Whether subconscious or conscious, all forms of modern architecture follow the Bauhaus philosophy in some aspect, whether it is the material, colour, form, or pattern. This case is in parallel with the Şakirin Mosque considering its overall simple exterior design, lighter colour scheme, its exterior and interior structure. Indeed, Fadıllıoğlu has given importance to the functionality over form in many aspects of the Mosque, which are elaborated in the following chapters.

Chapter 1

General Overview on the Bauhaus Architectural Style

The literal translation of ‘Bauhaus’ denotes to ‘construction house’ in German, which is logical in the sense that before all axioms, philosophies and statements surrounding the Bauhaus movement, the Bauhaus concept simply started as an art and design school founded by Walter Gropius in 1919. He founded the Bauhaus in Weimar, Germany with the primary objective, “to reimagine the material world to reflect the unity of all the arts” (Griffith Winton, 2020). Having the vision to unite art and design, Gropius described how the act of combining sculpture, painting and architecture into a single creative expression can be integrated into anyone’s daily routine and presumably improve living conditions. He argued that the way properties were built should develop following the era of the machine, post-World War One, meaning architecture should advance as the world develops. Taking inspiration from the Arts and Crafts movement, modernism and constructivism, Walter Gropius was able to translate these ideas to the Bauhaus school in Dessau, Germany by building a new structure (namely, “Bauhaus Dessau” displayed in **Figure 1** below) with pale concrete walls and large windows, exemplifying Bauhaus ideology. Between 1919 and 1933 the Bauhaus movement revolutionized architectural and aesthetic thinking and is still in practice today.



Figure 1 - "Bauhaus Dessau" in Dessau, (www.bauhaus-dessau.de, n.d.)

However, not all Bauhaus members specialized in architecture, for example, Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, another key German-American architect, designed several different models of chairs such as the "Tugendhat chair" which in present-day commonly features itself in office furniture. Rohe was also known to be 'the modernist architect who led the Bauhaus to its end' and is famous for designing American skyscrapers such as the "Seagram Building" in New York as seen in **Figure 2** below. This shows how Bauhaus principles can be applied to any design concept, proving its increasing popularity.



Figure 2 - "Seagram Building" in New York, (Wikipedia Contributors, 2018)

One of the most predominant characteristics of the Bauhaus is the fact that the integrity of the craft materials is always retained. This indicates that the significance of the materials used in the construction of anything Bauhaus related should remain in their honest and natural form to reflect the true nature of buildings and objects. With great emphasis on technology, the Bauhaus movement encouraged modern technologies to succeed in a modern environment.

Bauhaus workshops focus on mass production, many prototype products were developed in the Bauhaus where the designs are kept rational with a strong belief that it is useless to add excessive ornamenting as it can lead to overcomplication and degrade the functionality. Constantly developing, the Bauhaus revolves around new attitudes and unseen ways of construction where artists and architects are required to constantly invent new forms of design, subsequently the reason why the Bauhaus philosophy grew effortlessly.

Undoubtedly, the Bauhaus principle favours practicality and functionality in a minimalistic manner. Most Bauhaus inspired works of architecture usually share similar characteristics where materials such as tubular steel, concrete, glass and metal are favoured. For example, this is evident in the “Kornhaus Dessau”, where there is excessive usage of glass and tubular steel around the rim of the roof as shown in **Figure 3** below. The “Kornhaus Dessau” is a restaurant built in 1929 for tourists by formal Bauhaus member, Carl Fieger. It fulfils its purpose as a restaurant since the design follows the Bauhaus methodology of thinking which favours practicality and gives every feature a purpose. For

instance, the amount of glass used is thought out carefully to only be sufficient enough to exhibit the landscape as the building is positioned along the river ‘Elbe’. The locational choice also actively demonstrates the reasoning behind the unique structural shape as well as the use of certain materials since the structure follows a semi-circular plan and extends into an elongated cube, complementary to the surroundings in colour and landform in shape, in a way that is both geometric and functional.



Figure 3 - “Kornhaus Dessau” in Dessau**,** (www.bauhaus-dessau.de, n.d.)

Other common features of the Bauhaus would include flat roofs, smooth facades, steel-based frames and a cubed shape for buildings. In addition to this, the colour scheme is also kept less vibrant, more neutral or sometimes sombre, for example, black, grey or light tones. This is usually done with the purpose of reducing visual pollution since using natural colours allow buildings to blend in with their surroundings. Such structures were designed with the main motive of fulfilling their purpose, thus function is initially given more importance rather than the aesthetic. Hence designs are kept plain and straightforward as the main influence behind the Bauhaus movement was modernism, where there is a strong belief in perfectionism, simplicity and geometry.

Referring back, this is noticeable in the “Bauhaus Dessau”, as shown in **Figure 1**. The building is very minimalistic and simple, it uses a neutral colour palette mostly leaning towards lighter tones such as white and grey. Furthermore, the structure is composed of cuboid-based shapes along with the excessive usage of glass and concrete, a clear showcase of the Bauhaus principles. Since the structural aesthetic of the building already differs from the other townhouses located within the same whereabouts, the colour scheme is chosen to be less vibrant, slightly subdued in a way that wouldn’t make it look out of place, and possibly camouflage within the similar tones of the roads and concrete pathways.

Not only does the Bauhaus principle follow the old saying “less is more” termed by Ludwig Mies van der Rohe, but it is mostly revolved around the well-known design axiom “form follows function”. This famous design axiom was devised by an American architect, Louis Henry Sullivan in his essay titled “The Tall Office Building Artistically Considered” in 1896 and was seen as the base of modern design, an essential motto in the Bauhaus movement. Sullivan was eminent both for this popular quote and his identification with the aesthetics of early skyscrapers. According to him, an architect should design a building to serve its intended function. He believed that architectural design should come second to the purpose and originate from the intended function of the building. In other words, "form follows function" meant that the functionality of any design was first and foremost.

Known to many as a “father of skyscrapers” and “father of modernism”, his attention towards the structure of taller buildings in the late 19th century became increasingly

popular, and over a hundred years later, the Bauhaus philosophy took Sullivan's axiom, which then created the foundation of the Bauhaus movement and has been utilized ever since for development in architecture and design, which is how the Bauhaus progressed into our modern timeline.

Chapter 2

The Şakirin Mosque

Mosques are predominantly places of worship and have a critical role in the social and cultural life of Muslims. They are one of the most repeated building types in Muslim countries and are a visual attraction and makeup one of the most significant landmarks in cities. Turkey is rich in mosques, and Istanbul is singly home to about 3,000 mosques types varying from traditional and historical to contemporary and modern ones, including the Şakirin Mosque.

The Şakirin Mosque is situated in Karacaahmet Cemetery, located in Üsküdar in the Anatolian section of Istanbul. Karacaahmet Cemetery is known as the oldest cemetery in Istanbul and is one of the largest burial places in Turkey. The Şakirin Mosque was commissioned by the Semiha Şakir Foundation, funded by the well-known Şakir Family and the construction took four years, finally opening for public use in 2009. The Mosque has a floor area of 500 square meters, sits on a 3,000 square meter platform, and has a capacity for 500 worshippers. The Şakirin Mosque was designed and constructed by a large team, which included the prominent architect Hüsrev Tayla and an interior designer, Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu, whose name is well-known in Turkey, and internationally. The team also involved stained-glass masters, a calligrapher and other international designers.

Apart from being one of the most modern mosques in Turkey, the Şakirin Mosque is also known as one of the few mosques in Turkey designed by a woman thanks to the

substantial designing input by female interior designer Fadıllıoğlu to architect Hüsrev Tayla's initial architectural project.

Mosques are usually designed in a way that makes them culturally stand out by using traditional patterns, cultural art and a style that generally expresses religion. Numerous mosques around the world have been built in a way that follows the traditional style without considering the progressive technological evolution that takes place and contemporary aesthetic norms. Nevertheless, many present-day architects are in the process of leading mosque projects in familiar and traditional frameworks, while being inclined to use modern materials and construction methods, with this there is the obvious issue of the mosque not being able to reflect its cultural origins or bear a resemblance to the original look. The 3D models below **(Figures 4 and 5),** depict a prototype of the Şakirin Mosque where the whole design is composed of the main prayer hall with a big freestanding dome and an arcaded courtyard complementing a similar size. This main structure is very similar to traditional Turkish and Ottoman mosques. On the other hand, the Mosque's exterior is quite plain without any ornaments since prayers originally take place indoors so more cultural importance is given to the interior design, hence the indoors areas of the mosque has more traditional Turkish features.

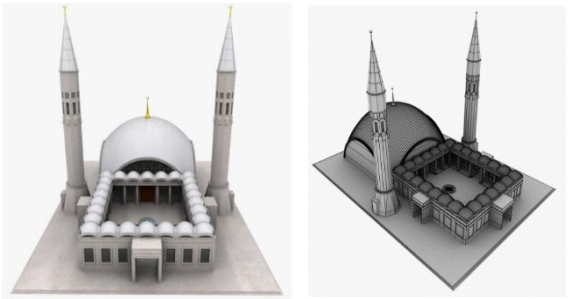


Figure 4 and Figure 5 – 3D Models of the Şakirin Mosque, (free3d.com, n.d.)

Chapter 3

The Link Between the Bauhaus axiom, “Form Follows Function” and the Şakirin Mosque

This chapter concentrates on different interior and exterior features of the Şakirin Mosque and overviews the link with the Bauhaus axiom, “form follows function”.

It is noticeable that the Şakirin mosque has a plain external aesthetic that lacks ornaments, decorations and the application of colours. **Figure 6** below depicts the dome and building exterior where the plainness of the mosque is highlighted. In the architecture of mosques, domes are a very important component in the design of mosques, both from the exterior and interior aspects hence why it is usually the most outstanding aspect of the mosque exterior, usually decorated with traditional handmade tiles, however, the Şakirin mosque is an outlier to what is deemed a ‘normal’ design for a mosque dome and instead, is more practical. The Şakirin Mosque has one big freestanding dome that touches the ground from four corners. It is made of grey aluminium composite (**Figure 6**) and is positioned in the centre of the site, keeping the praying hall underneath. The curved form of the dome helps create an echo inside so the prayers are more clear to hear for those who pray indoors, and less sound is emitted outside. The design of this dome is a suitable example where the function is favoured over form as the reasoning behind the round façade is to enhance sound travel in the interior, hence the link is formed with the Bauhaus principle.

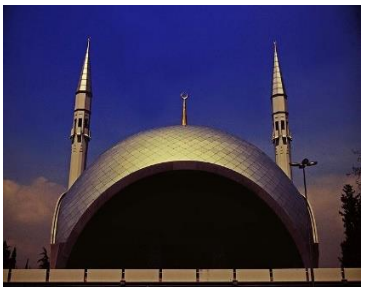


Figure 6 (beautifulmosques.com, n.d.)

Figure 7 below shows the recurring geometric pattern on the dome where this specific pattern also features itself in certain parts of the minarets, as well as other external facades. This geometric pattern does not have any cultural significance, on the contrary, it is a reciprocating modern design that can be identified in many different modern works of architecture such as skyscrapers.

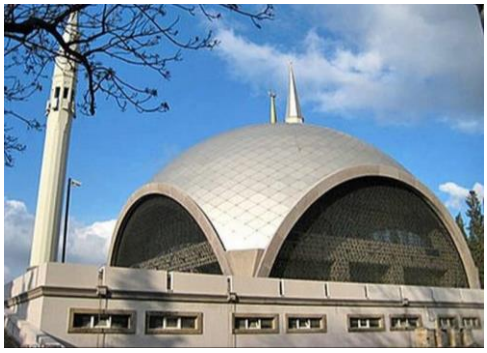


Figure 7 (admin, 2019)

The colour scheme of the dome has a very specific purpose of not outshining the environment, almost blending in. The dome's grey colour and the mix with beige tones ensures that the mosque does not look out of place and complements its surroundings as well as according to the subtle geometric designs. Moreover, the choice of having smooth white facades along with beige walls overall work well with the cemetery located under the trees, consequently following the Bauhaus principle.

Looking at the design of other important features of a mosque, it is known that both mihrab and minbar (shown in **Figure 8** below) are essential features of the praying ritual. Mihrab is a niche in the wall of a mosque that indicates the direction Muslims should face while praying, it is the architectural and symbolic focal point of religious buildings. A minbar is a pulpit in a mosque where the imam (the person who leads prayers in a mosque) stands to deliver sermons or speeches. In the Şakirin Mosque, both are designed with modern geometric shapes and plain textures, but bright colours. The mihrab is made from acrylic, opposing to traditional ones with mosaic or tiles and has a turquoise colour, which is a traditional Ottoman colour. As noted by Fadıllıoğlu, mihrab and minbar express the characteristics of traditional mosque architecture within a contemporary framework.



Figure 8 (zfdesign.com, n.d.)

Prayers ordinarily take place indoors, hence why the interior design of the Şakirin Mosque has clearly been given much more traditional importance, but in general, the decoration is kept rather simpler compared to the Ottoman mosques. The design team led by Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu aimed to create a spacious and luminous area, which would simultaneously give a calm environment for devotion. The team did not prefer any flashy and crowded decoration in the main gallery, because the mosque is a place where one should be alone with oneself and turn to worship. Hence excessive ornaments, tiles, and heavy usage of

bright colours were avoided, lighter tones were chosen. The use of religious writing, traditional patterns and Islamic themes evidently make visitors feel more familiar with the traditional mosque design they are used to and create a more welcoming feel, contrary to the plain and blander exterior.

The interior of Şakirin Mosque is surrounded by windows from all three sides which are accompanied with decorative gilded metal panels and are decorated with verses from the Qur'an. Sunlight between these two panels are reflected, providing the interior with natural light. The windows also provide a clear view of the trees surrounding the site, which creates a sense of praying in the nature. The main gallery floor is covered with traditional Islamic art embroidered carpet (shown in **Figure 9** below). There is a large chandelier of glass raindrops, further emphasizing the concept of praying in the nature. Overall, Ottoman and Seljuk art motives were used in various places of the main hall. All these interior elements along with the play of light collectively give a calming feeling which invites worshippers to focus and pray.



Figure 9, (Uyanan Gençlik, n.d.)

Having a separate praying section for women only is a clear illustration of the “form follows function” axiom and a demonstration as to how mosque designs are constantly in the process of improvement, taking into consideration the growing role of women in society. In traditional or Ottoman mosques, the women section is situated at the back of the main gallery and rather aimed to be designed invisibly since the Muslim world sees “women staying at the back or sides” as a practical matter given that the physical act of praying should stay rather in private but also degrading the significance of women in an area of worship. Taking another famous mosque as an example, “Blue Mosque”, it does not go unnoticed that the prayer areas for women remain to be the back of the mosque and the sides, whereas men can pray at the front and in the middle. Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu carefully designed what she calls the ‘women gallery’ (can be seen in **Figure 10** below) and wanted to ensure both genders get an equal experience of praying, instead of one gender going favoured and the other being located at the back. The ‘women gallery’ was placed on a special terrace, which is quite luminous and is in the main gallery, where they can see the minbar easily where the view women see while praying is quite spectacular with the chandelier.

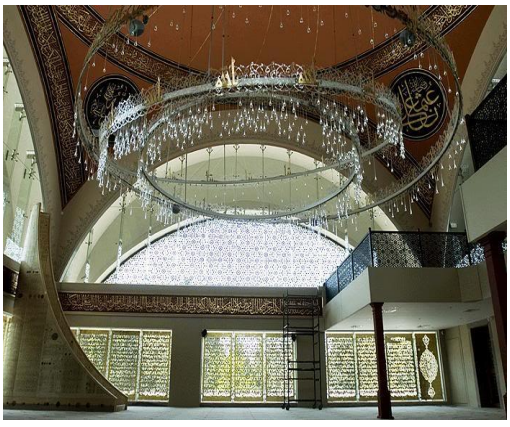


Figure 10 – ‘Women Gallery’, (beautifulmosques.com, n.d.)

Conclusion

Opened for public use in 2009, the Şakirin Mosque is one of the leading contemporary mosques in Turkey. Its architectural style is far from traditional mosque architecture and takes into account having a plain and simple exterior design with a freestanding dome, absence of traditional walls through the use of modern materials and introduction of specific elements to improve the functionality of the mosque and make it more accessible such as underground car parking areas or the design of a prayer hall separate for women only.

Zeynep Fadıllıoğlu and her team have taken ideas either subconsciously or consciously from the Bauhaus philosophy (including the “form follows function” motto) and incorporated these into the design and construction of the Şakirin Mosque. Traditional elements of generic mosques such as the dome, minaret, mihrab, pulpit, ablution area and courtyard have not been omitted, however, adjusted to adapt to today’s needs and keep up with the modernisation of ancient architecture.

Fadıllıoğlu was able to integrate the advancement in modern design and materials, the cultural aspects and requirements, and the Bauhaus axiom ‘form follows function’ into the design of the Şakirin Mosque, where people can pray in a safe and religiously appropriate environment. Referring to Fadıllıoğlu’s Podcast (www.youtube.com, n.d.) with an Italian Art Director, Antonio Mon Freda, Fadıllıoğlu believes that modernity in Turkey is heavily influenced by the Western world and therefore, in the end, Şakirin Mosque became a

fusion of old and new design concepts, using traditional as well as modern materials such as colours from the Ottoman and Seljuk period mixed with acrylics and contemporary designs.

Looking at the structure in detail, the exterior design of Şakirin Mosque is not very complex, and in fact, the structure is similar to traditional Turkish mosques but unembellished without any ornaments, with an insipid exterior colour along with the use of modern materials such as concrete, aluminium, metal and glass.

An important feature is the fact that the Mosque is built on a large plaza of which is put into use as parking, displaying the consideration of the “form follows function” concept by Louis Sullivan as the ground level car parking makes the visit more convenient. On the other hand, crucial features of the mosque are kept for symbolic reasons, such as the minarets.

Looking at interior features, the mosque mirrors many traditional features, such as the location of mihrab and minbar, culture-specific colour scheme, various Ottoman design elements and Islamic calligraphy. The function of a mosque is to create a suitable environment where people can pray and practise their religion, and this generally takes place indoors. To enable this, the designers created a spacious and bright environment by using large windows under the big dome, which was also done to blend the structure with its surrounding trees. Another important feature of the ‘form follows function’ concept was evident in the women's prayer section. Fadıllıoğlu purposely placed the women’s

section in one of the most beautiful parts of the dome to make sure that both genders are given the equal experience of praying and do not feel discriminated against.

It is widely believed that Ludwig Mies van der Rohe's work has presumably ended the Bauhaus era, but taking the Şakirin Mosque into account, and general modern-day architecture, it is clear that traces of the Bauhaus still exist, even if not intended. The Bauhaus philosophy is successful and strong to the extent where it has subliminally made its way into the buildings in which we live today.

To sum up everything that has been stated and investigated, the Şakirin Mosque follows the "form follows function" axiom to a considerable extent along with some other principles of the Bauhaus. While we see many aspects of the Bauhaus philosophy, we also encounter strong features of the traditional mosque architecture as well as Ottoman and Seljuk ideologies. As stated in the Semiha Şakir Foundation book, the Şakirin Mosque successfully couched traditional elements within a modern architectural grand design.

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